

UNGEGN Strategic Plan
and
Programme of Work
2021-2029

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FOREWORD

Message from the Chair

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Message from the Director

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Director UNSD

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The ‘new’ United Nations Group of Experts on Geographical Names (UNGEGN) was established by the United Nations Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC) resolution 20/18/2

in November 2017, replacing both the United Nations five-yearly Conferences on the Standardization of Geographical Names and the former UNGEGN.

Recommendation 1 of the first session of the new UNGEGN held in New York, 29 April to 3 May 2019, adopted by ECOSOC as decision E/2019/230 (dated 23/7/2019), approved the development of a draft strategic plan and programme of work to be undertaken by the UNGEGN Bureau:

Recommendation 1

The Economic and Social Council:

1. Decides that, in close consultation with States Members of the United Nations, the Bureau of the United Nations Group of Experts on Geographical Names should undertake the development of a draft strategic plan and programme of work for the new Group of Experts, which, inter alia, should take into account:
2. The mandate and structure of the Group;
3. Support for the creation of new national geographical names authorities and strengthening the operation of existing ones;
4. The establishment of funding mechanisms (such as a trust fund) to support the implementation of the strategic plan;
5. Appropriate branding and publicity for the Group;
6. The focus and core goals of its parent body, the Economic and Social Council;
7. A suitable planning timeframe;
8. Also decides that the draft strategic plan and programme of work shall be circulated to Member States for consideration prior to adoption at the second session of the United Nations Group of Experts on Geographical Names.

Accordingly, the Bureau in cooperation with convenors of the current Working Groups, has prepared this draft Strategic Plan for the period 2021 to 2029, in consultation with Member States, which have been formally consulted three times. The first consultation was done at the start of the exercise in October 2019, which asked Member States to identify national geographical names standardization issues and priority actions. The second consultation in June 2020, invited Member States to review and provide comments on the first draft of the Strategic Plan. Based on the feedback received, the Bureau prepared a revised version of the draft Strategic Plan, which was combined with the first draft of the Programme of Work and circulated in February 2021 for the third round of consultations.

This document presents the vision, values and aims of UNGEGN, together with the following five strategies and their collective alignment to the relevant goals of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.

1. Technical expertise
2. Relationships, links and connections
3. Effective work programmes
4. Culture, heritage and language recognition
5. Promotion and capacity building

For each strategy, the main achievements, current status and future needs are noted, followed by the presentation of the Programme of Work responsibilities, outputs and timeframes up to 2029.

Two sections of the document are devoted to financing and monitoring, reporting and evaluation. In addition, the document includes a SWOT (strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats) analysis, a brief history of UNGEGN, the current organization chart, and implementation framework.

Presentation of the draft Strategic Plan for UNGEGN's acceptance will take place at the 2nd Session of UNGEGN scheduled for May 2021.

INTRODUCTION

Brief History of UNGEGN

ECOSOC resolution 715A (XXVII) of 1959 encouraged nations to have a national organization for the standardization of geographical names and to set up a group of experienced consultants from interested governments. Since the first meeting of this group in 1960, 30 sessions have been held, with the name UNGEGN formalized in 1972. From 1967 to 2017, 11 five-yearly conferences were convened, providing forums to encourage national standardization, to promote international dissemination, and to endorse a single standardized and scientific romanization system for each non-Roman-script language.

For nearly 60 years, UNGEGN established a cooperative framework, followed up conference resolutions and promoted geographical names standardization, through its geographical/linguistic divisions and topical working groups, publications, website and training activities.

In 2017 the time was appropriate to review the conference and session structure and working methods with a view to operational efficiencies, cost-savings and improved decision making. As a result, the conferences and UNGEGN were discontinued and a new UNGEGN was established (ECOSOC 2018/2), to be convened every two years starting in 2019, with the existing mandates. UNGEGN now has full authority to set its strategic direction and adopt resolutions to be submitted to ECOSOC.

Outreach

As an expert body of ECOSOC, UNGEGN engages to strengthen communications with other UN bodies, providing advice on the use of standardized geographical names within their programmes; this in particular links to geospatial needs of UN-GGIM and the 2030 Agenda on Sustainable Development, as well as to the cultural heritage value of names relevant to a range of objectives and activities of the UN. As avoiding ambiguity in geographical names has economic and social benefits, and supports infrastructure development, UNGEGN also collaborates with non-UN international organizations, especially those with related scientific and technical interests. UNGEGN extends the promotion of its ideals and practices on standardization to the media and to the general public.

SWOT Analysis

A SWOT analysis of Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities and Threats was undertaken to consider internal and external factors affecting UNGEGN's current situation and its future operations. The following SWOT diagram was created by the UNGEGN Bureau and Secretariat. It assisted the Bureau to understand UNGEGN's position and provided a framework that helped to guide preparation of the Strategic Plan and Programme of Work.

UNGEKN's Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities and Threats

VISION

Every country to have a fully functioning and globally-aligned structure and policy framework, based on common principles for national standardization of authorized geographical names that identify location and respect the associated culture and heritage, and to have these names easily accessible for national and international use - facilitating consistent worldwide use of geographical names to foster communication and cooperation.

VALUES

Inclusive, Collaborative, Respectful, Relevant, Influential:

- i. We will work inclusively and collaboratively, aiming at consensus-building and harmony;
- ii. We will protect and uphold the integrity of our outcomes, demonstrating respect, expertise, professionalism and political neutrality;
- iii. Our products and outcomes will be solution-oriented, relevant, user-friendly, innovative, and fully and equitably accessible; and
- iv. We will share our knowledge, offer education, plan for succession, promote good practices and make an impact with our strategic direction.

AIMS

1. Raise awareness of the value and benefits of national and international geographical names standardization.
2. Facilitate the creation or improvement of national geographical names standardization principles, policies and procedures.
3. Recognize, respect and promote the value of geographical names as significant elements of cultural heritage, language and identity, including those of indigenous peoples and regional and minority groups.
4. Enhance, nationally, regionally and globally, the maintenance and dissemination of standardized geographical names data.
5. Consider, contribute to and endorse a single standardized and scientific romanization system for each non-Roman script language; systems are proposed by donor countries, and intended for international use. Recommend methods of writing geographical names from non-written languages.
6. Provide an active forum for Member States to exchange information, discuss and learn of

good practices on the standardization of geographical names, including their use in geospatial information systems.

7. Provide leadership in the implementation of resolutions and recommendations adopted at the former United Nations Conferences on the Standardization of Geographical Names and at the sessions of the Group of Experts.

8. Be recognized as the main source of expertise on a global level on standardization of geographical names for Member States.

9. Contribute geographical names expertise and advice to the work of other United Nations bodies, including those addressing the 2030 Agenda and the Sustainable Development Goals, taking note of their suggestions.

10. Collaborate with relevant non-United Nations organizations.

11. Involve relevant stakeholders to contribute to the standardization of geographical names and to promote their use.

STRATEGIES

Strategy 1: Technical Expertise

i. Deliver technical expertise and advice to interested parties in Member States for geographical names standardization, including romanization and quality geographical names data and gazetteer management as well as interoperability;

ii. Develop, extend and share good data management practices of Member States; and

iii. Identify trends on developments and future direction for geographical names data management and encourage the use of innovative methods, integrated approaches and technological advances to further the aims of UNGEGN.

Strategy 2: Relationships, links and connections

i. Strengthen UNGEGN's existing collaboration vis-à-vis other United Nations activities (including the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, and programmes of UNECA, UNESCO, UN-GGIM and UNPFII);

ii. Collaborate with non-United Nations scientific and academic bodies to provide expertise on geographical names standardization and create synergy to promote the work of UNGEGN and United Nations Member States; and

iii. Create new strategic partnerships with different stakeholders (both UN and non-UN bodies) to address the needs of UNGEGN as new challenges emerge.

Strategy 3: Effective work programmes

1. Encourage active participation and promote compatible standards and methods in the work undertaken by Member States to contribute to UNGEGN's aims;
2. Deliver products, outcomes, policy guidance and advice that support coordinated activities at national, divisional and international levels, taking note of UNGEGN resolutions and recommendations and leveraging social media, mobile applications and web-based tools;
3. Ensure that UNGEGN's organizational structure is appropriate, efficient, relevant and impactful to deliver maximum value to Member States; and
4. Encourage exchange of knowledge, good practices and experience among Member States, aided by Divisions and Working Groups, to facilitate development of legislation and policies on geographical names standardization at the national level.

Strategy 4: Culture, heritage and language recognition

- i. Declare, promote, celebrate and demonstrate that geographical names matter because they recognize unique culture, heritage and language that connect people to physical locations;
- ii. Promote good geographical naming practices that acknowledge people's place in the world;
- iii. Recognize that geographical names are a source of identity, encourage recognition of heritage and equality, and support indigenous, regional and/or minority groups' language revitalization and preservation; and
- iv. Contribute to building technical capabilities, such as developing guidelines, legislation, communication tools and databases to enhance culture, heritage and language recognition.

Strategy 5: Promotion and capacity building

- i. Raise awareness of the importance of using standardized geographical names and their role as a crucial element of geospatial information;
- ii. Enhance the visibility of UNGEGN through its publications, improved communications, outreach, networking and partnerships;
- iii. Assist Member States in their capacity building and in the development and management of geographical names standardization; and

iv. Develop funding strategies to enable UNGEGN to assist Member States in achieving national geographical names standardization.

Alignment of Strategies to the UN Sustainable Development Goals

UNGEGN recognizes the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) are the blueprint to achieve a better and more sustainable future for all. They address global challenges, including those related to poverty, inequality, climate, environmental degradation, prosperity, and peace and justice.

The monitoring of SDGs should be adequately supported by thematic analyses based on a set of geospatial data, of which geographical names are a core element. Therefore, optimizing the use of nationally authorized geographical names should be a prerequisite, for which UNGEGN's expertise will be advantageous. This use of nationally standardized geographical names applies to all seventeen SDGs.

UNGEGN, through cultural, heritage and language recognition will help meet the “Transformation: leave no one behind” agenda including the poorest and most vulnerable, and countries in need of special attention. Particularly, UNGEGN will contribute to achieving Goal 11.4 “Strengthen efforts to protect and safeguard the world’s cultural and natural heritage.”

Promoting UNGEGN principles for standardizing geographical names by means of assistance, capacity building, inclusive participation in UNGEGN meetings and democratic dissemination of UNGEGN principles and issues is an underlying factor for success in:

1. Promoting sustained, inclusive and sustainable economic growth
2. Establishing resilient infrastructure
3. Reducing inequality within and among countries
4. Making cities and human settlements inclusive, safe, resilient and sustainable
5. Promoting peaceful and inclusive societies for sustainable development, and
6. Building effective, accountable and inclusive institutions at all levels

Dissemination of UNGEGN principles and standards for geographical names helps strengthen the means of implementation and revitalize the global partnership for sustainable development.

Connections with other relevant UN bodies will be pursued to ensure that UNGEGN is managing its contribution to achieving relevant UN-SDGs.

PROGRAMME OF WORK

Strategy 1: Technical Expertise

Current status and assessment

UNGEGN has promoted and provided policy, consultancy and technical advice to national standardization programmes on geographical names collection, management and dissemination, to training courses as well as on innovation and research activities. This has comprised the support of multipurpose database solutions as an essential part of spatial data infrastructures for national, regional and global use in the context of a broader geospatial information management:

Workshops and Training Courses

1. Training Courses on Toponymy have been supported with contributions to technical issues like data modelling, interoperability, database applications etc. conveying the message of standardized geographical names data being essential within a national geospatial information management
2. Workshops have been organized in conjunction with UNGEGN Sessions focusing on topics like data collection, categorization and modelling, interoperability, database applications or lessons learned through national and international geographical names programmes or projects
3. Presentations have been given on geographical names data management topics at international events

Databases and applications

1. Advice has been provided to the improvement of the Geographical Names Database of UNGEGN (UNGEGN database)
2. The "UNECA Africa GeoNyms database/gazetteer initiative" has been promoted, complemented and supported, mainly within Training Courses on Toponymy
3. The establishment of regional databases/gazetteers of geographical names (like in Europe or in Asia and Pacific) has been promoted

Data integration methods

1. Policy, consultancy and technical advice have been provided to the UN-GGIM activities related to the fundamental data theme ‘Geographical Names’
2. Advice has been provided for the integration of geographical names data into the monitoring of sustainable development goals (SDGs) according to the UN 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development
3. The use of persistent unique identifiers has been promoted as a crucial element of consistent geographical names within a wider geospatial information management
4. The use agreement of romanization systems within the UN has been achieved to enable systematic transfer between non-Roman and Romanized-script languages; comprising information sharing on other systems for writing systems without a UN-approved system
5. The use of Unicode consortium encodings has been supported for a correct data transfer of all characters and diacritics (including those beyond the 26 basic letters of a Roman alphabet)

Some further needs: The cooperation with and the contribution to activities of other UN bodies and Member States on cross-sectional tasks and issues like ‘Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) monitoring’ or ‘Linked (Open) Data’ have to be strengthened and supported. Clarity and assistance on the implementation and use of UN-agreed romanization systems have to be promoted further – both within the donor country and at the global implementation level. In general, geographical names data management has to be discussed in close relation with issues of romanization and of cultural heritage, language and minorities.

Action items, actors and time frame

Strategy 2: Relationships, links and connections

Current status and assessment

UNGEGN has initiated and maintained to varying degrees, links with UN departments and agencies and non-UN scientific/technical organizations and groups, with either formal or informal liaison structures. Liaison with many groups has been active and effective, leading to provision of advice on the appropriate use of geographical names.

UN departments/agencies

1. ECOSOC: UNGEGN has reported through the UNCSGNs or directly following sessions
2. UNESCO and UNPFII: special presentations at UNCSGNs; individual Member States considered geographical names for recognition as intangible cultural heritage
3. UNECA: cooperation to further standardization of geographical names in countries of Africa; Task Team for Africa participated at meetings in Addis Ababa; UNECA organized a geographical names forum in Botswana and created Africa Geonyms - free database/gazetteer software for Member States' use
4. UN-GGIM: established cooperation to address Agenda 2030 and SDGs, including provision of advice on fundamental data theme of "Geographical Names" and ongoing contribution as members of the UN-GGIM Working Group on Fundamental Geospatial Data Themes

5. UN Documentation Division: recent liaison to advise on geographical names use within the UN; past interaction with terminology staff regarding country names data in UNTERM
6. WHO, UNGIS, OCHA, HABITAT, UNEP, UN Map Library: informal links and individuals have participated in UNGEGN sessions.

Non-UN commissions and organizations

Participation and leadership of UNGEGN experts in academic conferences of scientific bodies, so promoting the work of UNGEGN

1. ICA: long-established liaison; achievements such as on-line Toponymy Training Course
2. ICOS: a strong link, particularly for academic UNGEGN experts; UNGEGN experts have contributed to and edited issues of “Onoma”, presented at Congresses, and the terminology groups of the organizations have cooperated for common good.
3. IGU: collaborated to establish ICA/IGU Commission on Toponymy

Monitoring of and contribution to international standards pertinent to geographical names and associated databases

1. ICANN: provided advice on proposed domain name submissions
2. IHO: formal liaison, with particular cooperation on undersea and maritime feature names, for example SCUFN and its documentation
3. Unicode Consortium and OGC: formal liaison arranged for encoding and exchange standards
4. ISO: UNGEGN has Class A Liaison status with TC211 (Geographic Information/Geomatics); an UNGEGN expert currently chairs TC46/WG3 (Conversion of Written Languages); UNGEGN experts are also participating in the work of other ISO groups (e.g. TC46/WG2 - Coding of Country Names and related entities)
5. SCAR: liaison for data in the Composite Gazetteer of Antarctica; advised on naming principles
6. Links to groups providing toponymic training in keeping with UNGEGN’s needs
7. PAIGH: liaison with regard to toponymy training courses (Central & South America; in Spanish) and ICUTE (association of universities) that has established toponymic training
8. Initiation of other links
9. Google Earth: representatives have regularly attended UNGEGN sessions and made special presentations; individual Member States have as a result established contacts to ameliorate their national geographical names data used by Google
10. ICIPN: liaison with the Council was established in 2010, but only informal in nature
11. IMO, World Bank, ESRI, FIG: informal links; individuals have participated at UNGEGN sessions

Some further needs: Some links should be strengthened, a wider liaison network needs establishing and more “persuasion” is likely required for user groups to access and use nationally standardized geographical names. Greater cooperation is now required within the UN framework, creating a stronger link with ECOSOC and fostering cooperation with UNECA to further the standardization of geographical names in Africa.

Action items, actors and time frame

Strategy 3: Effective work programmes

Current status and assessment

UNGEGN has sought efficient ways to share commonly agreed principles on geographical names standardization and good practices of Member States through a series of discussions, resolutions, recommendations, products and outcomes. Its organization structure including Working Groups and Divisions has been established to support effective operation of its work programmes.

Participation, products, outcomes, policy guidance and advice

1. An increasing number of Member States have participated in the former Conferences and sessions so far, established common principles of the standardization of geographical names, shared their experiences, and benefited from good practices of others. However, there are still Member States which have not yet participated and/or have problems in participating due to lack of awareness, funding, etc.
2. Products of more than fifty-years of geographical names standardization have been published or compiled and are available from the UNGEGN website, including reports of meetings, individual working papers, special presentation materials, three manuals (basic, technical and training), a glossary of terms (with a searchable database), a list of country names, the World Geographical Names database and Toponymic Guidelines for Map and Other Editors of more than 40 Member States (links provided). Publications need to be reviewed for possible updating to accommodate current trends of geographical names standardization. Toponymic Guidelines are expected to be available from an extended number of Member States.
3. Resolutions adopted at the eleven former Conferences provide good guidance for the national

standardization of geographical names in each Member State. They have been compiled in a compendium and in a searchable online database in six and five languages, respectively. However, there should be more awareness of the resolutions as a reference for the national standardization of geographical names.

4. A growing number of Member States have established geographical names authorities to facilitate organized management of geographical names, which is expected to be extended to more Member States.

Modalities and organizational structure

1. Following the decision of ECOSOC in 2017 to create a combined body of the former UNCSGN and UNGEGN with the name UNGEGN, its first biennial session was convened in 2019 over a period of five days. The new UNGEGN is searching for a more organized operation as an inter-governmental body representing Member States of which experts play a crucial role.

2. Each of the Working Groups (currently 9 in operation, 3 disbanded), one Task Team and one Coordinator has been carrying out or completed its specific goals as missioned by UNGEGN. Twenty-four geographical/linguistic Divisions have functioned as groups of Member States to support regional or language-based grass-roots interaction on geographical names standardization. The linkage and cooperation between Working Groups and Divisions need to be enhanced to secure expertise or synergy effects. The function and operation of Divisions need to be reviewed and, if required, adjusted in the new modalities of UNGEGN.

Some further needs: More precise monitoring and evaluating UNGEGN's work programme is needed in order to increase its efficiency. More elaborated relevance of UNGEGN to achieve the 2030 SDGs should be addressed in its work programmes. Ongoing encouragement and enabling is needed for all Member States to have national geographical names standardization policies and legislation.

Action items, actors and time frame

Strategy 4: Culture, heritage and language recognition

Current status and assessment

UNEGN has encouraged the development of principles and practices to support the less tangible social concepts of geographical naming. These include connection to place through traditional, ancestral, historical, cultural, and language associations. Recognizing the importance of these human needs acknowledges a sense of place and why geographical names matter.

Beyond the practical need for communicating location identification, geographical names preserve identity and belonging.

Recommendations, initiatives, programmes and training

1. As more emphasis was given to geographical names as cultural heritage, a number of UNCISG Conference resolutions on this subject were passed, for example, VIII/9, IX/4 and X/3. Several resolutions have promoted collection and recognition of indigenous and minority toponyms (for example, II/26, V/22, VIII/1, IX/5, VII/9, IX/10); and UNGEGN Recommendation 5 (2019), follows up I/16 and I/20 in addressing geographical names from unwritten languages.
2. Following the 8th Conference in 2002 a Working Group was established to promote the recording and use of Indigenous, Minority Group and Regional Language geographical names; in 2012 it took on a simpler name with the wider scope of “cultural heritage”.
3. “Geographical names and cultural heritage” is a regular Agenda topic at UNGEGN sessions and was the theme of the UNGEGN Information Bulletin, No. 48, May 2015.
4. Symposia organized by UNGEGN, Divisions or Working Groups have included: “Toponyms in multilingual areas”, Netherlands (2005); and geographical names as cultural heritage, Vienna (2008), Seoul (2014), Florence (2015). A workshop on implementing resolutions on commemorative names was held during the 29th UNGEGN session in Bangkok (2016).
5. Special presentations on intangible cultural heritage have been made by UNESCO at Conferences in 2007 and 2012 and some Member States have worked towards possible UNESCO recognition of particular groups of geographical names.
6. At both Conferences and Sessions individual Member States have presented documents reflecting their progress in various areas of cultural heritage, identity, multilingualism, indigenous naming, etc. and these are available on the UNGEGN website.
7. UNGEGN has reached out to indigenous organizations, such as UNPFII and ICIPN to participate at UNGEGN sessions.
8. The UNGEGN toponymy training manual, the on-site and online training courses, the basic manual and the Media kit include sections and presentations on geographical names as cultural heritage.

Achievements

1. From its initial technical roots, UNGEGN has over the years increasingly placed significance on the cultural value of geographical names, and this topic has been included in UNGEGN’s toponymic training programmes.
2. Many UNGEGN participant countries have made and continue to make remarkable progress on their domestic work on declaring, promoting and celebrating the unique connections between culture, heritage, language and geographical names.
3. UNGEGN has recognized the requirement for support to, for example, unwritten languages, which are necessarily from regional and/or minority language communities.

4. UNGEGN has also recognized the need to understand exonym use and the Working Group on Exonyms is active in examining this topic. There are many available publications including an ongoing book series, Name & Place, comprising the Working Group's papers.

5. Participation and leadership of UNGEGN experts in academic conferences of scientific bodies considering cultural heritage, e.g. International Congress of Onomastic Sciences, so promoting the work of UNGEGN.

6. There has been some provision of advice to organizations (UN and non-UN) on the benefits of recognizing the intangible cultural heritage through geographical names.

Some further needs: Some Member States have significant work to do in declaring, promoting, celebrating and recognizing the importance of the unique connections between culture, heritage, language and geographical names. Relationships with external bodies could be further developed to strengthen and enhance the connection that geographical names have with culture and heritage, e.g. UNESCO, UNPFII. UNGEGN could facilitate member states' progress in this field by sharing 'model' or 'example' case studies from other members, on particular issues. Greater support could be offered to develop writing systems for unwritten languages, thereby providing a means of representing geographical names in a standard way and allowing these to receive a wider audience. A financial impact may be relevant as the benefits of recognizing culture and heritage do not necessarily have an obvious tangible advantage, and therefore may be overlooked or side-lined by some Member States.

Action items, actors and time frame

As the scope of cultural heritage is wide there will be several formalized, structured and active Focus Groups within the WG on Geographical Names as Cultural Heritage:

1. Geographical names in relation to minorities and indigenous people
2. Legislation, policies & best practices relating to geographical names
3. Commercial and commemorative naming, including urban naming
4. Crowd sourcing for collecting stories behind the names
5. The names of unwritten languages
6. Naming within tourism and branding

Strategy 5: Promotion and capacity building

Current status

1. Up-to-date UNGEGN website, established in 2002, has been maintained and been through several re-iterations to address design and content, including: 1) The UNGEGN World Geographical Names Database (2004), 2) A searchable database of all resolutions and downloadable documents in four UN languages and two non-UN languages, 3) Information on UNGEGN's Divisions, Working Groups and Task Teams, 4) Reports from all the meetings under the auspices of UNGEGN, including working papers, conference room papers, special presentations and additional documents, 5) Publicity material, including manuals related to geographical names, brochures and media kit to publicize the work and goals of UNGEGN, 6) Information on toponymic laws and regulations regarding Member States.
2. Biannual UNGEGN Bulletin issues, since 2013 with thematic issues. Established as the de-facto media to report on developments and upcoming events in matters related to UNGEGN or within the scope of geographical names.
3. Wikipedia presence in multiple languages.
4. Twitter presence.

5. Enabling participation at UNGEGN events for members from developing countries through funding from a variety of sources to enable the participation in Conferences/Sessions.
6. Funds from UN Statistics have supported training courses in various parts of the world.
7. Press releases written and processed before and after Conferences and Sessions.
8. Presentations made by UNGEGN experts at academic and scientific conferences promoting the work of UNGEGN.
9. UNGEGN has assisted in capacity building by providing on-site training since 1982, essentially in response to Divisional needs, and has produced training modules available free through the website to all interested individuals in association with ICA.

Further work to be done: Generally, the work of UNGEGN and importance of geographical names standardization is still poorly understood and appreciated in many Member States and outside organizations.

1. Direct UNGEGN web presence maintains a good standard, although a number of sub-pages are in need of improvement.
2. UNGEGN World Geographical Names Database page has not been updated with the recent upgrade. In need of reinvention.
3. Member States contributions to web presence must be developed to ensure up-to-date information. Without requests/persuasion few UNGEGN experts provide updated information, such as national names authority data, contact information, city names for the UNGEGN database, etc.
4. Although many UNGEGN publications continue to be relevant 10-20 years later, content needs to be reviewed for updating.
5. Better arrangements need to be in place for the UNGEGN Secretariat to be able to update and provide visual and map representation, such information as Member States with national names authorities, Member States with toponymic guidelines, which Member States have supplied data to the UNGEGN database, where training courses have been held, etc.
6. Bulletin standard is high with relevant topics for information, capacity building, and toponymic issues. However, editorial proof-reading capacity in all UNGEGN languages must be ensured. To ensure relevance and actuality, a list of topics must be maintained and regularly updated. The development of templates for contribution could be beneficial.
7. Wiki-presence is good, regularly updated, although a more active editorial presence is necessary, as the current situation is under-robust.
8. Social-media presence adequate, although a more active editorial presence is necessary, as the current situation is under-robust. There is also room to improve on social media communication in intervals between meetings.
9. Mechanisms for providing funding for participants from developing countries in place. However, the funding situation is not robust therefore, an UNGEGN trust fund needs to be

established.

Action items, actors and time frame

IMPLEMENTATION FRAMEWORK

Organization Chart

Membership, Bureau, Working Groups, Task Teams, Divisions

The Group of Experts is composed of representatives of States Members of the United Nations, including experts appointed by Governments. In appointing their representatives, Member States designate experts with specific knowledge drawn from the interrelated fields of geography, cartography, geospatial information, linguistics and history.

Divisions of the Group of Experts comprise the major linguistic and geographical divisions of the world, as listed in the Appendix. Member States decide for themselves the division(s) to

which they wish to belong; some belong to more than one division. Each division is expected to stimulate activities in the standardization of geographical names within the division, through technical meetings, exchange of experiences, correspondence, etc. Currently, there are 24 Divisions that guide the work of UNGEGN during and between its sessions.

Working Groups are created to follow up topics and issues which cut across the divisional structure of UNGEGN. Currently, nine Working Groups are in operation. In addition, UNGEGN has a Task Team for Africa and a Coordinator for the Toponymic Guidelines. The current work plans of these Working Groups, Task Team and Coordinator are listed in the Strategic Plan. A working group is disbanded when it has fulfilled its mandate.

The Bureau is composed of one chair, two vice-chairs and two rapporteurs. The Bureau, Working Group convenors, coordinators and former chairs meet regularly through teleconferencing or face-to-face meetings.

Secretariat support to for UNGEGN is provided by the UN Statistics Division.

Monitoring, Reporting and Evaluation

The UNGEGN Strategic Plan and Programme of Work 2021-2029 provides a general framework of UNGEGN's activities to support the standardization of geographical names in each Member State. In order to achieve the vision and aims, the UNGEGN Bureau, Working Groups and Divisions will deliver and pursue the respective action plans as specified in each strategy. UNGEGN sessions held biennially will be an effective forum to report on the progress of the activities that each component of UNGEGN has achieved during the intersessional period, and to evaluate and make updates and amendments to the Plan, as appropriate. The UNGEGN structure including the Working Groups and Divisions will be assessed based on the efficiency of implementing action plans and, if needed, proposed to be reorganized. Each Member State is invited to report on its activities to implement the Plan in the UNGEGN sessions.

Financing

An important element in achieving the goals set out here lies in developing funding strategies to enable UNGEGN to assist Member States in achieving national geographical names standardization. A funding strategy is outlined under item 5.iv. Explore possibility of UNGEGN trust fund for capacity building and enabling participation. The outline sets the course for an establishment of a legal framework of an UNGEGN Trust Fund becoming a part of the umbrella UNSD Trust Fund, a time frame for funding attraction, and eventual launch.

Key to this work is the implementation of a Terms of Reference to provide a mandate for the establishment and purpose of the trust fund, including possible sources of funding, and which UNGEGN activities are to be supported from the fund. Approval of the UNGEGN strategic plan and programme of work 2021-2029 should secure the necessary mandate for creating an UNGEGN Trust Fund and paves the way forward to identifying donors in order to secure the necessary funds for a sustainable UNGEGN of the future.

APPENDIX

Linguistic or geographical divisions of the United Nations Group of Experts on Geographical Names

1. Africa Central Division
2. Africa East Division
3. Africa South Division
4. Africa West Division
5. Arabic Division
6. Asia East Division (other than China)
7. Asia South-East Division
8. Asia South-West Division (other than Arabic)
9. Baltic Division
10. Celtic Division
11. China Division
12. Dutch- and German-speaking Division
13. East Central and South-East Europe Division
14. Eastern Europe, Northern and Central Asia Division
15. East Mediterranean Division (other than Arabic)
16. French-speaking Division
17. India Division
18. Latin America Division
19. Norden Division
20. Pacific South-West Division

- 21. Portuguese-speaking Division
- 22. Romano-Hellenic Division
- 23. United Kingdom Division
- 24. United States of America/Canada Division

ABBREVIATIONS

UNGEGN and its Working Groups

United Nations and its bodies other than UNGEGN

UN Geospatial (former Cartography) <https://www.un.org/geospatial/>

UN-Habitat <https://unhabitat.org/>

UN Map Library <https://research.un.org/en/maps/>

International organizations, commissions and academic groups

Unicode consortium <https://home.unicode.org/>

Related terminologies